was so fond of the story of Hamza that he had memorized large sections of it, and as he walked through the corridors of his palace, he recited reams of it, ‘in the style of the storytellers’, with voice modulations and gestures. Sometime in 1562, Akbar decided that these storytelling sessions would be even more enjoyable with images to depict the events that were being described and gave the order for the largest single commission in Mughal history, changing the course of Mughal painting forever.

The taswir khana that Akbar had inherited from Humayun included a few Persian master artists such as Abd al-Samad and Mir Sayyid Ali; Dust Muhammad had died, possibly on the journey back to Hindustan. These artists had created only a handful of paintings since coming to Hindustan, but one of those paintings was a quite extraordinary image entitled ‘Mughals Visit an Encampment of Sadhus’. In this painting, Mir Sayyid Ali, a troubled, complicated artist, who, it was whispered, did not entirely have the Padshah’s favour, created a fantastical scene where elegant yogis were surrounded by a bustling horde—‘stately plump elephants; camels; flunkeys milking goats; cooks making bread and preparing meals; and musicians trumpeting fanfares to the family of Mughal visitors’. The great Persian emigré artist was clearly responding to this mesmerizing scene with foreign eyes and the art historian Stuart Cary Welch writes that ‘[Akbar] responded badly to Iranian graces; and he would not have been pleased to see Indian holy men transmuted into foppish courtiers, not even when they were Mughal ones’. But even if the Padshah was dissatisfied, the painting glows with the quintessential Persian fine attention to detail, exquisite ornamentation, and superb control that Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd al-Samad would transmit to their Hindustani students.

Now with the commissioning of the *Hamzanama*, a project that would take fifteen years, and would result in 1,400 paintings, the Mughal taswir khana was about to be reformed in the brazier of Akbar’s colossal ambitions. More than a hundred Hindustani artists, mostly Hindus from Gujarat, were trained in the miniature style in a surge of creativity and effort. An army of poets, gilders, bookbinders, and calligraphers were also hired and trained. By the mid-1560s, four volumes of images were completed and Mir Sayyid Ali, perhaps unsurprisingly, bowed out of the project and proceeded to Mecca. Abd al-Samad now took over and, by about 1577, all twelve volumes were completed. Each volume took about a year to complete and two lakh copper tankas were spent on each. The